ART

REVIVING A LOST ART

Contemporary artists reimagine the iconic 19th-century Bat-tala prints of Bengal in a new exhibition







(From left) Somnath Hore's woodcut 'Fear'; Subroto Mondal's woodcut 'Untitled'; Akbar Padamsee's lithograph 'Untitled'

An extraordinary visual art project breathes new life into the historic Bat-tala woodcut prints of 19th-century Calcutta. Presented by Art Magnum Gallery, *The Tradition of Bat-tala & Other Practices by the Printmakers* has been curated by Ina Puri, with contributions from co-curators Ananda Moy Banerji, Dattatreya Apte, Sushanta Guha and Saurabh Singhvi.

These black-and-white and sometimes hand-coloured prints were known for their religious and mystical themes, and served as book illustrations similar to Kalighat paintings. The Bat-tala area, meaning 'under the Banyan', was historically a hub for various community activities, including the local print industry. However, the advent of lithography and chromolithography led to its rapid decline, leaving behind a brief but impactful legacy.

"Bat-tala woodcut prints represent a rich but overlooked chapter in our artistic heritage. This exhibition is not just about revisiting history, but about reimagining it. We have challenged the artists to explore new technical possibilities while staying true to the spirit of Bat-tala. The result is a collection rooted in tradition and forward-looking in its execution," says Puri.

Artists have explored hand-coloured woodcuts through progressive techniques and digital colouring. Sujay Mukherjee's work engages in speculation about the content of the image carved into a woodblock, which is the only remaining piece from a group of multiple blocks originally necessary to

PHOTOGRAPHY

Picture Perfect

Veteran photographer **O.P. Sharma's** solo exhibition at Triveni Kala Sangam showcases his versatility



The Shridharani Gallery at Delhi's Triveni Kala Sangam is currently hosting *O.P. Sharma & the Fine Art of Photography*, a selection of 150 vintage prints from the veteran photographer's archives. The exhibition comes over 60 years after Sharma's first solo show, which was also at Triveni. Sukanya Baskar has curated the show, on till October 3, in collaboration with Rahab Allana, curator/publisher at the Alkazi Foundation for the Arts.

Sharma, acknowledged as a leading light of pictorialism in India, created striking portraits of some of the most influential figures of post-Independence India: Indira Gandhi, shehnai maestro Bismillah Khan, Hindi writer Agyeya, and so on. However, this exhibition also shines a light on Sharma's more unconventional works, like a series of Ellora photographs involving formalist-yet-playful experiments with light and shadow. "They're very different from the rest of his oeuvre," says Baskar. "For him, the Ellora photographs were a formal and compositional exploration of a medium. It was in line with his other experimental photographs, some of the most personal work he's done outside of portraiture."

During the 1970s, Sharma created publicity stills for four Indian films, including the American co-production *Shalimar* (1978). He started teaching photography at Triveni in 1980, and went on to teach for over four decades, only stopping after the pandemic. "Pedagogy was always a big part of pictorialism,"